

Rutte's Trump whispering faces stress test

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【要点】

- ・ NATO事務総長マーク・ルッテがアンカラサミットでトランプ米大統領がNATO同盟を脱線させないよう圧力を受けており、欧州同盟国の防衛支出増加を説得する外交交渉が試されている。
- ・ ルッテはトランプ大統領を関与させるため、視覚的援助と過度な称賛を含む手段を講じているが、この方法は一部のヨーロッパ人から批判されている。
- ・ 欧州議会議員らはルッテのNATO統一維持の取り組みを概ね評価しつつ、今後の成功が鍵となる点を指摘している。
- ・ ラトビアの議員はルッテのトランプ対応方法を「幼稚園レベルの大きな絵と文字」と皮肉っており、10年後の評価はルッテが天才か失敗者かで分かれると述べている。
- ・ ルッテが米国大統領に対して過度に追従していると、一部のヨーロッパ人から非難されている。

【メール原文】

POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By NICHOLAS VINOCUR GREET

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GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. Let's dive in:

In today's Playbook:

- How a proposed European Commission shakeup could worsen a feud with the EEAS.
- Why Romania's political crisis is set to continue until September.
- Faces in the crowd: Mark Rutte, David McAllister, Mărin Stăciaru, Giorgia Meloni, Dafydd Iwan, Christine Lagarde, Kaja Kallas, Kajsa Ollongren, Bernard Arnault and many more ...

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Nick discuss our big profile of Pedro Lourtie, the European Council chief's Kremlin conduit.

DRIVING THE DAY

ANKARA SUMMIT TESTS RUTTE: NATO boss Mark Rutte is under pressure to pull off another diplomatic feat this week: keeping U.S. President Donald Trump from derailing a landmark NATO summit in Ankara, as allies try to convince him they're paying their fair share.

Whatever it takes: Trump has continued to bash European NATO allies in the lead-up to the summit. But Rutte isn't giving up. The secretary-general has pulled out all the stops to keep the president involved, including large visual aids and lavish praise. But the method has proven controversial among some Europeans.

Performance review: As we gear up for the summit, and Turkish officials reportedly clamp down on opposition campaigners, Playbook checked in with senior European lawmakers and officials to see what they thought of Rutte's performance, after criticism of his "Daddy" comments and Trump's recent clash with Italian PM Giorgia Meloni.

The verdict: Broadly upbeat — with some big caveats.

'Doing the job': "Europe's interest is a united and coherent alliance at a time when our security environment is becoming much more demanding. And maintaining that unity among all allies is the secretary-general's job," said David McAllister, a German conservative MEP and chair of the European Parliament's foreign affairs committee. "Mark Rutte is doing his job."

Notes: The whatever-it-takes approach to Trump has to prove itself, said Mārtiņš Stakis, a Latvian Greens lawmaker on the Parliament's Committee on Security and Defense. "If we think of the book that will be written in 10 years, Rutte will either look like a genius who held NATO together through the hardest moment in its history ... or it will be something else."

Toddler props: As for Rutte's Trump method, Stakis said: "It looks like what we used in kindergarten: big pictures, giant letters." A spokesperson for NATO did not immediately reply to a request for comment.

Dutch factor: Some Europeans have accused Rutte of kowtowing too blatantly to a U.S. president who has no hesitation in dumping on NATO allies. But a senior EU official who has worked with Rutte for years defended the former Dutch PM, saying it was his "lack of ego" that made him fit for the job: "You cannot keep Dutch coalitions together for as long as he did if you have too much pride," said an official granted anonymity to comment. "That's what NATO needs."

The bottom line: Rutte has done his best to achieve success in Ankara. Allies are primed to show Trump how much they have increased defense spending. The main discussions will be short and sweet, Victor Jack reports. But, of course, things could still go wrong.

****What should we expect from this week's NATO summit?** POLITICO's Jan Cieski, Megan Messerly and Esther Webber will unpack the stakes in Ankara, including Ukraine, Iran, Trump's relationship with European allies and the future of NATO itself. Join us online on July 6 at 4 p.m. CEST. Register here ******

BIG AND BREAKING

FRANCE ON EDGE OVER LE PEN'S LEGAL FATE: The leader of France's far-right National Rally Jordan Bardella will find out Tuesday whether he'll be a presidential candidate next year, with a court ruling to decide Marine Le Pen's eligibility to run.

POWER BEHIND THE SCENES: The Portuguese chief of staff to European Council President António Costa has become known as the EU's "dealmaker-in-chief." But reaching out to the Kremlin has exposed Pedro Lourtie to criticism from some capitals.

THE HAND OF GOD: U.S. striker Folarin Balogun had his one-match suspension lifted so he can play in the Americans' last-16 game against Belgium on Tuesday morning, sparking outrage in Brussels . Reuters reports the decision followed a call from Trump to FIFA President Gianni Infantino. European football leaders are considering their next step.

Meanwhile ... England beat World Cup co-host Mexico 3-2 overnight in what observers are describing as one of the best games in the 2026 tournament, CNN reports . Even Trump outed himself as a fan of England striker Harry Kane.

SUMMER HOLI-DELAY: The Commission has launched a new push in a bid to ensure its new biometric Entry/Exit System doesn't leave non-EU citizens stranded in lines at the border as holiday season begins, according to a letter seen by Playbook's Gabriel Gavin .

HATE SPEECH CLASH: European Parliament President Roberta Metsola will today remind MEPs that they should all "feel safe," following outrage over chants of "send them back" during a debate on the EU's return regulations last month. Metsola is waiting for a report before making a decision on sanctions targeting the lawmakers behind the chants, the Parliament's press service said.

Mounting pressure: "Real sanctions was my first ask ... second ask was mandatory training for all vice presidents on hate speech," Renew European MEP Abir Al-Sahlani told POLITICO, following a meeting with Metsola. Green MEP Saskia Bricmont warned the situation "can quickly get out of control if it's not clearer [that] misbehavior is simply not allowed."

INSIDE THE COMMISSION

EXCLUSIVE — COMMISSION REFORM PLANS: The European Commission is considering options to bolster its external-facing policy units, as part of an internal reform process. The proposal includes combining several units into one powerful department for external relations, according to three EU officials.

Foreign-policy push: The idea — one of several under review — would be to maximize the Commission's external-policy reach, in keeping with the aims of a "large-scale review " being led by Budget Commissioner Piotr Serafin. If adopted, the proposal could add to concerns about a turf war between the Commission and the bloc's diplomatic branch, the EEAS.

Look closer: A supercharged DG for external relations could include elements, in whole or in part, of DG TRADE or DG MENA, the department in charge of Middle East and North Africa policy. Other options under consideration include reorganizing DGs along geographic or thematic lines, per the officials who were granted anonymity to discuss confidential plans.

When to watch: Some of this thinking is due to be shared with Commission employees during an all-staff meeting on July 13, with commissioners to be briefed in subsequent weeks.

Asked about the plans, a Commission spokesperson wrote in an email: "This review is an important internal exercise for the institution. It is about making the organisation stronger, more agile and better equipped to service European citizens in a rapidly changing world."

Stand back: Under President Ursula von der Leyen, the Commission has taken steps to bolster its foreign-policy credibility, leading to friction with the EEAS, which is headed by top EU diplomat Kaja Kallas. The reform options being considered show the Commission isn't stepping away from foreign policy — quite the opposite.

EEAS not standing still: Kallas is also taking steps to strengthen the EEAS, having recently unveiled a new leadership structure, which includes former Dutch Defense Minister Kajsa Ollongren as secretary-general, replacing Belén Martínez Carbonell. Further reforms are expected to be unveiled after the summer.

The bottom line: The battle over who controls EU foreign policy is only getting started.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

European Central Bank President Christine Lagarde said she could leave her post before the end of her term, in October 2027, to take part in France's presidential election. That prompts the question: How is an ECB president chosen? Candidates are put forward by countries that use the euro. The Eurogroup (the body where finance and economy ministers of the eurozone meet) then picks a candidate and informs the European Council. The European Parliament and the ECB's own governing council are consulted, with the Parliament's Economic and Monetary Affairs Committee holding a hearing with the nominee. The European Council makes the final decision and there needs to be a reinforced qualified majority (at least 16 of the 21 eurozone countries representing 65 percent of the population). ECB president terms are eight years — non-renewable.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked you to send a video about how you listen to the show for your chance to win merch. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

ROMANIA'S EU FUNDS AT RISK

CRISIS DEEPENS: Romania won't have a new government before September, USR leader Dominic Fritz told Max Grier, as MPs go on holiday from this week: "The deadlock is real. It's not a tactical position of the parties. It's not political posturing."

No go: Fritz said his liberal party, together with the center-right PNL, refuses to allow the Social Democratic Party (PSD) back into government, after it brought down the three-party centrist coalition in April, with the support of the far right.

The deadlock: Fritz wants a minority government made up of USR and PNL, which Socialists should support to "demonstrate that this is the direction they want to support and not the new majority that they formed with the far right."

But the Socialists want a minority government led by their chief Sorin Grindeanu. A possible compromise, involving dividing the term in two, failed to take off as the parties disagreed over which side would start governing first.

Clearing the runway: "In two months, there's enough time for any landing zone to make itself evident," Fritz said.

EU funds in the balance: Around €5.1 billion worth of EU Covid-19 recovery funds are at risk, as Romania races to meet an end-of-August deadline for key remaining reforms, according to the USR policy department. It's the fate of these funds that's the most politically contentious. Still, Fritz said he was confident Parliament could pass the reforms in time, although he couldn't "guarantee the political goodwill of the other parties."

5 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

PRESIDENT PRESSES MEPs: European Parliament President Roberta Metsola has taken the rare step of asking lawmakers to vote again after they rejected a proposed law allowing tech companies to scan their platforms for child sexual abuse content.

TURKEY READY FOR EUROPEAN DEFENSE EMBRACE: Turkey has a grim human rights record and strong ties with Russia and China. But Trump's wavering commitment to European defense is prompting allies to reassess closer military cooperation with Ankara.

ITALY OPPOSES KIRILL SANCTIONS: Italy has joined Bulgaria in voicing concerns about plans to sanction Russia's Orthodox Patriarch Kirill, according to three EU diplomats informed on the deliberations.

EMERALD ODYSSEY: The first informal meeting of Ireland's EU Council presidency is an EPSCO Council gathering focused on social affairs and already has diplomats and EU officials grumbling that the venue is too remote. The meeting is being held in Ballina, roughly three hours and 40 minutes from Dublin by train. An Irish presidency official told Playbook the government had committed itself to holding at least 25 percent of its informal Council meetings outside Dublin.

WILDFIRE RESPONSE: Hundreds of firefighters battled wildfires in Portugal, Greece and Spain on Sunday, with Spain and Italy sending reinforcements to Portugal to help with a massive blaze that has been burning for more than three days, AP reports .

BRUSSELS (AND PARIS) CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny, top of 29C.

DELAYS POSSIBLE: Brussels public transit authority STIB announced possible disruptions to metro lines, trams and buses today due to a strike. The industrial action is being organized by CGSP, a public sector trade union, in response to STIB's current hiring freeze. Status updates will be available starting at 6 a.m.

UNLOVED INFLUENCERS: The European Council's experiment with social media influencers isn't going down well with the Brussels hacks. The Association de la Presse Internationale, which represents Brussels-based foreign correspondents, says it's still worried about the 12-month pilot project granting creators access to EU summit sidelines and press spaces.

Not API: The problem is that influencers aren't bound by the same editorial standards, transparency rules or accreditation requirements as professional reporters, the association argues. API President Dafydd ab Iago said: "We remain concerned that the initiative blurs the line between independent journalism and influencer content, threatening the integrity of political reporting."

PARTY BATTLE OF AMERICA 250: U.S. Ambassador to France Charles Kushner and his team threw quite the birthday bash for the United States on Friday, Josh Berlinger writes in. But was it better than the Brussels semiquincentennial celebration?

Not your average backyard BBQ: No major Paris parks were closed off for this party. The shindig was held at the ambassador's residence, an 18th-century mansion once owned by the Rothschild family. More than 2,000 people — an intimate affair compared to the 8,850-strong Brussels bash — gathered on the property's expansive garden, just a stone's throw away from the Elysée Palace. Among them was Europe's richest man, LVMH CEO Bernard Arnault, fêted as the guest of honor. "Everyone knows I am French, but deep inside there is something American in me," Arnault told the audience in English.

A different tenor: The Five Guys truck from last year's party was nowhere to be seen and there were no corn dogs or milkshakes, as there had been in Brussels. But there were fries, mini-cheeseburgers, pigs in blankets and fajita bites, alongside a smorgasbord of high-end finger foods, ceviche and gelato — arguably more appropriate options when you're being serenaded by Andrea Bocelli.

Don't let the redcoats forget: Other highlights included a flyby of two Rafale jets and the Eiffel Tower emblazoned with USA 250 and lit up in red, white and blue. Paris' fireworks may not have been framed by a major city landmark, like the arch in Brussels' Cinquantenaire Park, but they were fired off from a spot that offered some poetic justice: the British ambassador's residence next door.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Germany's chancellor and finance minister are both out selling the draft 2027 budget but they're employing very different communication strategies .

London: Prime Minister-in-waiting Andy Burnham returns to London today to navigate some of the policy headaches that emerged over the weekend.

Paris: A motion of no-confidence in the National Assembly against the government's handling of the recent heatwave is expected to only attract left-wing MPs .

Washington: Just 27 percent of American adults believe the United States founders would be proud of what the country has become, according to a new POLITICO poll .

AGENDA

— Cypriot President Nikos Christodoulides and Cypriot European Deputy Minister Marilena Raouna participate in the concluding press conference of the Cypriot Presidency of the European Union at 10 a.m.

— EU High Representative Kaja Kallas meets Uruguayan Foreign Affairs Minister Mario Lubetkin and Belgian Foreign Affairs Minister Maxime Prévot.

— The European Parliament's plenary session in Strasbourg begins with debates at 5:30 p.m., with Parliament President Roberta Metsola presiding over the session's opening at 5:00 p.m. Defense Commissioner Andrius Kubilius participates in the plenary.

— Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis participates in a European Parliament plenary debate with the European Investment Bank Vice-President Robert de Groot, starting at 6:30 p.m.

- EU employment and social affairs ministers hold an informal meeting at 10 a.m. in Ballina, Ireland, with European Commission Executive Vice-President Roxana Mînzatu participating.
- Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič receives Uruguay's Lubetkin.

BIRTHDAYS

MEP Anna Zalewska; former MEPs Geert Bourgeois, Michiel Hoogeveen, Nathan Gill and Ángela Vallina; European Commission's Peter Wagner; Duško Marković, former PM of Montenegro; Nursultan Nazarbayev, former president of Kazakhstan; Dalai Lama Tenzin Gyatso; former U.S. President George W. Bush; European Parliament's Đorđe Bojović.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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